



Department for Education

2025-0028093

Catherine McKinnell MP
Minister for School Standards

Justin Madders MP

By email: justin.madders.mp@parliament.uk

Your ref: [REDACTED]

13 August 2025

Dear Justin,

Thank you for your correspondence of 25 July, on behalf of your constituent, Ms Lauren Moore of [REDACTED] regarding qualification award bodies.

I was disappointed to read of [REDACTED] negative experience with alternative education provision. High and rising school standards are at the heart of the government's mission to break down barriers to opportunity and give every child the best start in life. The government has established an independent curriculum and assessment review, covering ages 5 to 18, chaired by Professor Becky Francis CBE, an expert in education policy.

The review is committed to ensuring all pupils have access to a broad curriculum and achieve positive outcomes. The objective is to update the curriculum across key stages 1 to 5, including with the goal of developing a comprehensive, inclusive, and engaging framework that equips students with the knowledge and skills necessary for their future life and work. The government remains committed to enhancing inclusivity within mainstream schools.

The review group has published an interim report that sets out its initial findings and confirms the key areas for further work. One of the areas identified for further work is exploring how the inclusivity of the assessment system could be improved for young people with more profound special educational needs and disabilities (SEND), which I hope assures Ms Moore of the importance of SEND reform to the department. The review's final report and recommendations will be published in autumn, at which point the government will respond. The interim report is available on the GOV.UK website at: tinyurl.com/5FEV6T4T.

Regarding Ms Moore's request to set up a new body to regulate qualifications she has developed for learners with special educational needs and disabilities and to regulate her own awards, this would create a conflict of interest. Ofqual, the independent regulator of exams and assessments in England, already has responsibility for ensuring that regulated qualifications reliably indicate the knowledge, skills, and understanding students have demonstrated. Ms Moore may wish to contact Ofqual and seek advice from them on how she could establish an awarding organisation and offer Ofqual regulated qualifications for learners with special educational needs and disabilities. Ofqual can be contacted via the GOV.UK website at: tinyurl.com/SZK7ZYT6.

It may also be helpful to set out the support currently available to learners with special educational needs and disabilities to access regulated qualifications, including GCSEs and A levels. The Equality Act 2010 requires awarding organisations to make reasonable adjustments where person with special educational needs or disabilities would be at a substantial disadvantage in undertaking an assessment. Schools and colleges are responsible for making applications for reasonable adjustments for their students and must ensure they have supporting evidence in place.

As applications for reasonable adjustments must be made prior to an exam taking place, early collaboration between parents, students, schools, and teachers is essential to identify possible arrangements. This may include speaking to the special educational needs co-ordinator, who coordinates the process within the school and will be able to advise on the types of evidence needed to support an application.

Thank you for writing to me. I hope that this response is useful for Ms Moore.

Yours,

A handwritten signature in blue ink, reading 'Catherine'.

Catherine McKinnell MP
Minister for School Standards